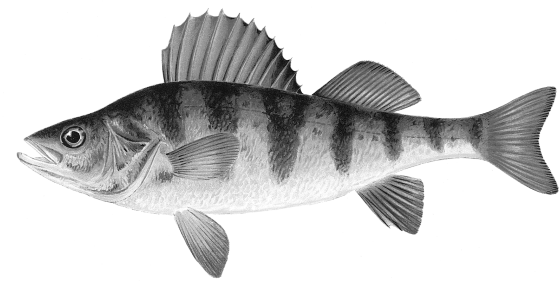


Yellow Perch

A daylight schooling fish — and the walleye’s opposite

Perca flavescens



Yellow or Barred Perch — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Size here

Spawn

Eats

Six to eight dark **vertical bars** over a yellow-green body, with orange lower fins. Two separate dorsal fins, the first spiny. Unmistakable.

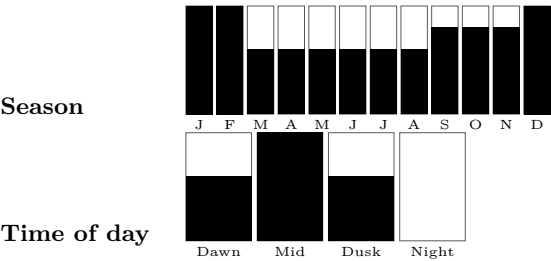
6–10 in. A 10 in perch is a fine fish and among the best eating in either lake.

45–52 °F, April, and unlike any other fish here the female lays a long accordion-folded ribbon of eggs draped over weeds and brush. You will see them in the shallows.

Insect larvae, small crustaceans, minnows and fish eggs. Perch are also the primary food of walleye and pike — which is exactly why they school.

Habit

A daytime feeder. Perch shut down at night, when walleye switch on. They travel in tight schools on the bottom.



Where

Pine

North

Bottom

Winter

The deep weed edge at spot **5**, the flats around the base of the bar **4**, and the 15–30 ft bottom generally.

Spots **1**, **3** and **4**. Shallower than on Pine because of the stain.

Perch stay on or near the bottom on clean sand, gravel or the base of weeds. If you are more than a foot off the bottom you are fishing over them.

One of the best ice fish in either lake, on the same 15–30 ft flats.

How

Best rig

Move to find them

Stay on them

A small jig tipped with a minnow head, a piece of crawler or a waxworm, fished right on the bottom. Or a drop-shot with a very short tag, *see the **drop-shot** sheet*.

Perch schools are tight. If you catch two and then nothing, the school moved — move with it rather than waiting.

When you find a school, drop straight back down immediately. A hooked fish drags the school with it and a slow re-bait costs you the whole group.

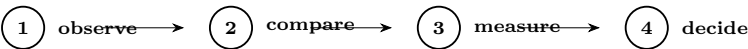
The lesson to teach

Perch and walleye eat the same food in the same water but never at the same hour: one has eyes built for daylight, the other for dusk. That single fact explains most of the daily rhythm of both lakes.

Worth knowing

Schools sort themselves by size	Perch shoal by year class, so the fish you catch in one spot tend to be the same length. If they are all too small, move — you are not going to find a big one in that school, because it is not in it.
The egg ribbon	Female perch lay a single accordion-folded gelatinous ribbon, sometimes two metres long, draped over weeds and brush. Nothing else in these lakes does this, and in April you can find them in the shallows.
Daylight only, and that is unusual	Perch have poor low-light vision and essentially stop feeding at night — the exact inverse of walleye, which hunt them. Predator and prey partition the same water by the clock.
They are the currency of the lake	Perch are the primary forage for walleye and pike here. A good perch year is followed by good walleye growth, and the size of the perch you catch tells you what the predators are eating.
Age	A 10 in perch is commonly five to seven years old and is a genuinely good fish anywhere in Wisconsin.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Are there six to eight vertical bars and two clearly separate dorsal fins, the first spiny?
Rule out	Young walleye are longer-bodied, toothed, and show the lower-tail white tip; body colour alone is unreliable.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: fold the first dorsal with a wet hand and read total length on a rigid board.
Field proof	Bars, separate dorsals, and compact perch proportions must agree. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. Panfish: 25 per day in total, open all year, no minimum length. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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